# The Dead Internet Theory and the Rise of Human-Like Online Bots

Anne Göbel

HTWK Leipzig

agoebel1@stud.htwk-leipzig.de

06.12.2025

**Abstract**

With the rise of AI in practically everything comes the destruction of humanity in online spaces. This paper outlines the current research, a brief overview of how AI is restructuring human-made content on the Internet, and provides a short overview of the classification of social media bots.

## 1 Introduction

The Dead Internet Theory, an idea that has been around for a while,[1] states that our Internet today is mainly driven by bot-traffic and AI-generated content made to look like real human interactions. While the idea was merely speculative back when it first came into public discussion, today it is shockingly real and growing to worrisome levels every day.

Since AI is rapidly developing, so are methods of detecting AI in social media - where before you looked at individual accounts to find generated content, you now map clouds of different bots to find similarities in how and to whom they talk, to detect if a certain account is a real human being or not. [2]

The current trend within online spaces is that humans are becoming increasingly unable to distinguish between real people and chat bots, with recent studies finding out that only two out of five interactions are correctly flagged as AI-generated by real participants. [2]

## 2 Classification of Bots

The Dead Internet Theory did not start with the rise of LLMs, but rather earlier with the rise of bots. Large Language models exemplified a problem that was already well on its way to threaten the Internet that we know today. Lopez-Joya et al. outlines several different strategies for categorizing online bots while providing their own system describing malicious and non-malicious bots, including spambots, social manipulation bots, personalized attack bots, entertainment bots, customer service bots, and more. They drew on an assortment of earlier bot detection research and reshaped the current understanding with their own categorization. To first find bots in a forest full of humans, they clustered a set of accounts and sorted them as shown in Fig. 1 [2] We can clearly see five emerging clusters. Cluster 1 (C1) is grouped by number of URLs per tweet, C2 is classified by an exemplified amount of mentions per tweet, C3 is characterized by a low number of hashtags and features related to followers and friends, and Cluster 4 and 5 are misclassified accounts that contain no bots. However, with the rapid development of AI in online spaces, once bots are classified properly, new bots will emerge that will outshine the previous generation in their ability to copy human-like behavioral patterns.

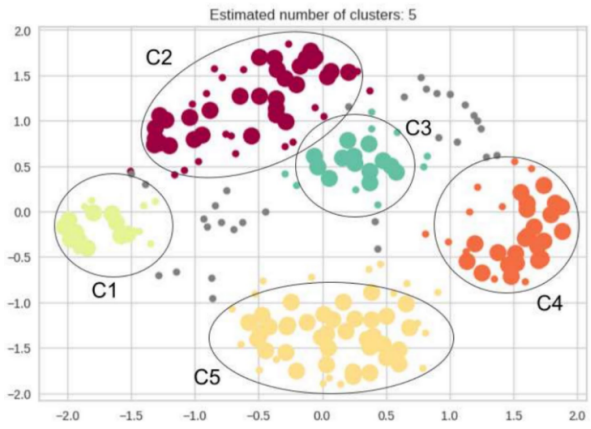



Figure 1: Clusters of Twitter user accounts

[1] Some say the theory originated over ten years ago, while others say it emerged in 2021, and others claim it's from the late 2010s - no one seems to know for sure where and when it started. [6] [3] [4]

## 3 Social implications

Human connection is on the decline when 50% of the Internet consists of bots. Interactions are a coin toss between a real human and a chatbot. Before, forums and personal blogs made up a large part of the internet. Now they are generated and re-fed over and over again into the same LLM that made the website in the first place, destroying space for original content and making it harder to find. Algorithms are programmed to exploit the need for a quick dopamine hit rather than ensuring content stays original.[3]

Online culture is on the verge of destruction, since AI Bots steer truth in a direction of their owners' choosing, forming cracks in our shared social understanding of what's real and what's not. Berry developed, among other things, the theory of "Inversion" - The point at which Bot detection systems treat AI-generated content as real and human-generated content as unreal.

It is unsurprising that with the ever-growing discrepancy between the super-rich and the common folk, people turn to shadier means of gaining a steady stream of income, as seen in Spotify artists that generate and upload music and employ a litany of bots to then listen to said music to produce money. [1]

There is virtually no countermeasures against the overuse of AI-Bots in social media, in fact, there is an entire social media network called Chirper based on describing your own bot and then letting it loose in a self-contained playground to chat with other bots - all while the user can watch this.[2]

## 4 Conclusion

AI is fundamentally restructuring our understanding of truth and reshaping social consciousness within online spaces. Bots reach deep in every aspect, be it humor, politics, normal everyday interactions, ads, or even therapy.[5] In 2017, 71% of accounts that discussed the US stock market were bots[2] and in 2022, Meta removed 1.6 billion fake accounts.[1] Social media bots are on a non-stop climb and as new detection systems rise, so too will new, harder-to-detect social bots rise. We created a zoo for ourselves and are slowly pushing our own species out in favor of a shadow of ourselves. The lines between bot and human blur further every day and it is only a matter of time until we need more long-term strategies to ensure the authenticity of our beloved online spaces.

[2] https://chirper.ai/

## References


[1] David M. Berry. "Synthetic media and computational capitalism: towards a critical theory of artificial intelligence." en. In: *AI and SOCIETY* 40.7 (Oct. 2025), pp. 5257–5269. ISSN: 1435-5655. DOI: 10.1007/s00146-025-02265-2.

[2] Salvador Lopez-Joya et al. "Dissecting a social bot powered by generative AI: anatomy, new trends and challenges." en. In: 15 (Mar. 2025), p. 7. ISSN: 1869-5469. DOI: 10.1007/s13278-025-01410-5.

[3] Prathamesh Muzumdar et al. "The Dead Internet Theory: A Survey on Artificial Interactions and the Future of Social Media." In: *Asian Journal of Research in Computer Science* 18.1 (Jan. 2025). arXiv:2502.00007 [cs], pp. 67–73. ISSN: 2581-8260. DOI: 10.9734/ajrcos/2025/v18i1549.

[4] Gizem Özgürel et al. "Dead Internet Theory in Theoretical Framework and Its Possible Effects on Tourism." en. In: *Journal of Lifestyle and SDGs Review* 5.1 (Jan. 2025), e04327–e04327. ISSN: 2965-730X. DOI: 10.47172/2965-730X.SDGsReview.v5.n01.pe04327.

[5] Kay T. Pham, Amir Nabizadeh, and Salih Selek. "Artificial Intelligence and Chatbots in Psychiatry." en. In: 93 (Mar. 2022), pp. 249–253. ISSN: 1573-6709. DOI: 10.1007/s11126-022-09973-8.

[6] Yoshija Walter. "Artificial influencers and the dead internet theory." en. In: *AI and SOCIETY* 40.1 (Jan. 2025), pp. 239–240. ISSN: 0951-5666, 1435-5655. DOI: 10.1007/s00146-023-01857-0.